

RESEARCH PAPER

**BENEFITS OF APPLYING THE NON-SELF SUTTA TO OVERCOME
THE SUFFERING OF ILLNESS OF THE 15th DHARMA ENGLISH
DEPARTMENT STUDENTS AT VBU IN HO CHI MINH CITY**

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MINH CITY**

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

VBU = Vietnam Buddhist University

DED = Dharma English Department

MN = Majjhima-Nikāya

MA = Madhyama-Āgama

AN = Aṅguttara-Nikāya

SN = Samyutta-Nikāya

SA Samyukta-āgama

ABSTRACT

Illness and the path leading to the cessation of the illness' suffering are always the most concerns of humanity in general and monks and nuns in particular, especially during the the covid outbreak period. Although previous articles have demonstrated various ways to overcome the misery of illness, anguish has not been completely resolved. This study offers a method to contemplate the non-self nature of the five aggregates such as form, feeling, perception, mental formations and consciousness. To investigate the topic, a questionnaire, which included both qualitative and quantitative method, closed and open questions, was sent to fifty eight students of the Dharma English Department at VBU. As a result, most students totally agreed that the contemplation of the five aggregates is very necessary to overcome insecurity of mental health and regulate emotions. In which, the most important method is the reflection on the non-self of form and feeling. Consequently, researchers have clarified the practical benefits of practicing the Non-self sutta to absolutely eliminate mental suffering and improve physical health, i.e., remove sensation frightened of being sick, build a positive attitude and spread the same feeling to lay Buddhists, cure effectively patients with psychotherapy, attain mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom.

Keywords: non-self, suffering of illness, five aggregates, mental sufferin

INTRODUCTION

Many Buddhist scriptures mention ways to treat illness including physical and mental. Currently, these Buddhist sutras are pertinent since humanity has numerous illnesses. The International Scientific Conference on Cancer Prevention showed that Vietnam has the second-highest global cancer incidence, in 2022, with 182,563 new cases and 122,690 cancer fatalities. Vietnam has 11,620,769 Covid-19 infections and 500,000 people have dementia, reported by the Ministry of Health. These figures reflect a growing percentage of citizens who experience both physical and emotional sickness. In the Sallatha Sutta, the Buddha taught that: “Just as if they were to shoot a man with an arrow and, right afterward, were to shoot him with another one, so that he would feel the pains of two arrows; in the same way, when touched with a feeling of pain, the uninstructed run-of-the-mill person sorrows, grieves, and laments, beats his breast, becomes distraught. So, he feels two pains, physical and mental” (Samyutta Nikaya 36.6). By doing this, the Buddha advised the Buddhist should conquer the second arrow, which is the sensation of anguish. The Sakalika Sutta recorded as follows: “Excruciating were the bodily feelings that developed within him — painful, fierce, sharp, wracking, repellent, disagreeable — but he endured them mindful, alert, and unperturbed.” (Samyutta Nikaya N 1.38).

In reality, through the recent Covid pandemic, current researchers have observed that monastics at VBU continue to feel insecure and fear getting sick. These worries stem from the rigid regulations and routines at VBU. Buddhist students are required to do assignments related to the coursework, chores, and cultivation. However, individuals who get ill are incapable of attending to study, work, and practice. Monks and nuns face various challenges, including failing, working and chanting lateness. For incurable diseases and high risk of death, Bhikkhus and Bhikkhunis are anxious of unfulfilled goals, which causes feelings of uselessness and unhappiness. In addition, at VBU, students are requested to live in the boarding houses, so it is difficult to transfer to specialist hospitals for illness care. Due to lack of medical facilities and finance to cure serious ailments, Buddhist Orders suffer from medical issues. Venerable Ajahn Sumedho (2004) states that: “the grief and fears derived from clinging into ‘self’. We stop fearing by letting go of the self.” In the Non-self sutta, the Buddha provides the remedy for cut off ‘self’ and mental insecurities. Thus, the authors elected to address the title of “Benefits of applying non-self sutta to overcome the suffering of illness of the 15th Dharma English Department (DED) students at VBU in Ho Chi Minh City”.

With the issues raised, the writers expect that monks and nuns clearly understand and apply the no-self theory to achieve the practical benefits. First, practitioners can stop feeling frightened of being sick. Second, Bhikkhus and Bhikkhunis build a positive attitude and propagate the same feeling with lay Buddhists. Third, DED students effectively treat patients with psychotherapy through the non-self doctrine. Finally, Buddhists orders achieve mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom. To complete the objectives that have been mentioned, the study concentrated on particular questions below:

1) Why is the Sutra of No-Self necessary for the DED students at VBU to practice in order to get rid of illness-related suffering?

2) How do DED students apply the non-self doctrine to deal with the suffering caused by illness?

With these objectives, 60 DED students, 15th course, at VBU, are the study's major objective. The Buddha's teachings in the Sutta of No-self, Anattalakkhana-sutta, Samyutta Nikaya, III-66, serve as the theoretical foundation for this study. Besides, the writers have also cited other pertinent documents to enhance the clarity of the research.

The research team chooses Vietnam Buddhist University in Ho Chi Minh City as the background of research. The 15th DED students are our research objects. To clarify this research paper, the research team uses both qualitative and quantitative method. The research performs five parts:

Chapter 1: Introduction

Researchers provide the basis information such as the background information, the objectives, the scope of the study, the methods, and an outline of the study.

Chapter 2: Literature review

The chapter expresses the achievements and limitations of the former research.

Chapter 3: Research Methodology

The study has qualitative and quantitative method. The questionnaire is designed to investigate the opinions of the participants.

Chapter 4: Results and discussion

The research team described, analyzed the collected results from the questionnaire. The research team proposed several methods to solve the above problems.

Chapter 5: Conclusion

The research team summarizes the advantages and disadvantages of the study and limitations of the study to have a deeper research orientation later.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Definition

1.1. Suffering of illness

According to the Saccavibhaṅga sutta (MN 141) and the goals of medicine (Cassel, 1982), the term of “suffering of illness” comprises of both physical and mental suffering; however, because of the above objectives, the current researchers emphasize the mental insecurities of sickness. The bodily pain includes headache, eye-sore, ear-sore, throat-sore, diphtheria, withering away, and dysentery (Thich Minh Chau, 1991). Due to physical discomfort has an impact on mental health, as proven by the teachings in the Nakulapitusutta (SĀ 147, T II 573a01, SN 22.1) as follows: “His mind not having followed in turn and given rise to vexation and pain, he does not get frightened, obstructed, worried, [distressed], and passionately bound. With feeling ... perception ... formations ... consciousness it is also like this. This is called the body suffering from disease and the mind not suffering from disease.” (Anālayo, 2012b). The aim of researching the mental misery of illness is to describe and understand people’s experience of suffering when confronting with a disease or health problem situation (Montoro et al., 2012).

Buddhism and medical therapy studies mostly address psychological anguish. Montoro et al. (2012) present the various manifestations of suffering by directly interviewing the patients. First, suffering is defined as a multidimensional and dynamic process such as the feelings of fear about the experiences in hospital, originating in the sudden or treacherous appearance of a disease or health problem demonstrated by a recorded patient experience: “I’m very scared of the anesthesia, and mainly of not waking up. I’m terrified of that. It’s something you can’t control, because you don’t know what they’re going to do nor how it will be” (Montoro et al., p. 624). Montoro et al. (2012) also state that: “the disease turns into an invalidating factor that prevents subjects from following their normal work rhythm.” by analyzing a patient’s reaction as follows: “It wasn’t just my disease, but the external pressure I was getting... because all the time they were calling me from the medical inspection, which caused huge tension for me because the medical inspector told me that he would discharge me because the falls had caused many months of sick leave” (p.625). Besides, in the Sukhumālasutta (AN 3.39), “When an

uneducated ordinary person -who is liable to get sick, not being exempt from sickness- sees someone else who is sick, they're horrified, repelled, and disgusted, overlooking the fact that they themselves are in the same situation. But since I, too, am liable to get sick, it would not be appropriate to be horrified, embarrassed, and disgusted when I see someone else who is sick. Reflecting like this, I entirely gave up the vanity of health.” (Sujato trans., 2020).

1.2. Non-self

No-self is a fundamental term derived from Buddhism. Various sects of Buddhism interpret the non-self theory in somewhat different ways. In Early Buddhism, the concept of non-self rooted from the *anattā* (Pāli term) or *anātman* (Sanskrit term) refers to ‘not-self’ or ‘absence of independent self.’ (Nguyen Quy Hoang, 2019). To interpret clearly, this school analyses the non-self doctrine in relationship with the Dependent Arising (*paticca samuppāda*) and the five aggregates (*pañcakkhandha*). In *Abhidharmakośa-śāstra*, Vasubandhu supports that non-self doctrine is “knowing things as they really are” and is to break the barriers between individuals so that these selfish tendencies associated with the I-sense do not get a hold existence (Chadha, 2021). In other words, Chan (Zen) and Mahayana Buddhism assert that no-self is emptiness (*sunyata*), the emptying of permanency, immutable self-nature, or being (Chan, 2008). It means that nonself refers to the realization that the self or I lacks intrinsic existence (Shial, 2016). Van Gordon et al. (2015) extend further “The concept of Anatta clings to the belief that the state of delusional self or the art of being obsessed with oneself is the pioneer of all our suffering.” (p.15). Thus, the non-self state escapes from the delusion of the self, i.e., the end of suffering. It is the mind that is no longer attached to an existing self.

The brief content of the Non-self sutta (Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta)

In Pali canon, the Non-self sutta is found in the Samyutta Nikaya (S.N 21.59 or 22.59) and in the Saṃyukta Āgama 34 (SA 34). The Non-self sutta is known as the *Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta* (Pali) or *Anātmalakṣaṇa Sūtra* (Sanskrit) which is the second discourse delivered by Gautama Buddha.

The Non- self sutta mentioned the five aggregates (*Khandha*) and the three characteristics of existence (suffering, impermanence, non-self), which aids Buddhists in

discovering the causes of suffering and the way to the cessations of suffering. Suffering originates from the temporary and uncertainty of the five aggregates. The person made up of those five aggregates is nothing more than a composite, so there is no real "I" behind that person (Not-Self). Anyone who believes that this body is permanent and eternal certainly experiences pain. Hence, the concept of the selflessness of the five aggregates is a very important view which leads to liberation.

2. Self-grasping leading to mental suffering

In Buddhism, attachment is the origin of all kind of sufferings. Wing-Shing Chan (2008) declares “The Buddhist concepts of impermanence, no-self and emptiness are discussed to explain the Buddhist explanation for human suffering.” (p.253). When the ego exists and is accepted, the illusion of a permanent ego is the cause of human suffering. (Nguyen Quy Hoang, 2019). The self is a collection of states and attributes (Narmada, 2021), the idea of the self as an existential entity distorts the perception of truth. Shiah Y. J. (2016) asserts that the ego is not real. The entire Buddhist teachings are built around the denial of the self and the destruction of the sense of self, the root cause of suffering (Vargas, M., 2021). “If you do not get what you want, suffering is present” (Albahari, 2014) with the general condition of dissatisfaction and discomfort appearing first. A mind is too bound to ‘self’ and ‘my self’, which are the basic for suffering to arise as Nguyen Quy Hoang (2019) states that “people will have the illusion of a permanent self. This illusion is the reason to cause suffering for people” (p.20).

3. Practicing the Non-self sutta

The Lord preached that “anything that causes misery and is transient is not-self” (Samyutta Nikaya, III, 66). The Buddha also repeatedly emphasized not only that the five aggregates (khandhas) of being are “not-self,” but clinging to “self” also cause to suffer. Studies on the practice of the Anatta Sutra for the purpose of eliminating suffering in body and mind have been conducted.

3.1. Contemplating the impermanence of the five aggregates

The five aggregates include form, feeling, perception, volition and consciousness, which are the elements that make up the human body and mind. The first aggregate refers to the physical and material parts (rupa) and the remaining four aggregates belong to the mental part (nama) (Nguyen Quy Hoang, 2019). According to Bhikkhu Bodhi (2000),

essentially, the five aggregates are impermanent (anicca). No entity can exist independently without the combination of these elements. When these five elements disintegrate, that entity no longer exists. Practice contemplation clearly about the true nature of the five aggregates as a combination of many different conditions and those factors also change over time and space (Wing-Shing Chan, 2008). This combination is a law of nature. Whether the body or mind is healthy or sick, reflecting on the impermanence of the five aggregates will help the practitioner feel light, comfortable and ready to accept all undesirable things.

3.2. Contemplating the suffering of the five aggregates

It is called suffering because phenomenon does not exist eternally in a certain state. No one can be rich forever, be happy without sadness, and live forever without getting sick or dying. When reflecting on suffering, the Buddha explained how impermanence inevitably leads to suffering as in the Anatta sutra as

“So what does Bhikkhu think, is this body permanent or impermanent?

- World-Honored One, it is impermanent (anicca).
- What is impermanent is suffering or happiness?
- The Buddha is suffering.

(Samyutta Nikaya, III, 66)

Rupert Gethin (1998) proclaims that the nature of human suffering, pain or suffering (dukkha) theoretically in Buddhism can be analyzed in a very specific way, as follows:

Of course, something that is impermanent must be considered 'painful' (dukkha), according to the principles that we have found expressed in the second of the four noble truths: if we become Being attached and trying to hold on to things will inevitably change. and disappear, we will surely suffer. (p.137)

To end human suffering, the mind's attachment (upadana) or craving (abhiijjhana) must be eliminated from the things or concepts to which one is attached. (Wing-Shing Chan, 2008). Wing-Shing Chan (2008) also emphasizes that it is thoughts filled with

emotions of fear, anxiety, suffering, delusion or excitement, and so on. That are themselves the cause of discomfort, distorted cognition, misjudgment, and misconduct (p. 255).

3.3. Contemplating the non-self of the five aggregates

Selflessness is a concept used to refer to the state of having no attachment to anything, as the Sutta Nipāta confirms “Such a Bhikkhu who has abandoned desires and attachments, and has Having gained knowledge of this world, one has entered the realm of eternal peace, the unchanging state of Nirvana.” (Fausball, 1881, p.33). When this body of five aggregates is contemplated deeply within their nature, everything is empty (Nguyen Quy Hoang, 2019). Thus, there is nothing to gain or lose, rather a more general view of the reality that exists to stay away from all forms of desire and passion, allowing us to be free from all forms of desire and passion (Kiseong, S. & Ariarajah. W., 2017). The Buddhist teaching of anatta does not declare the absence of individuality or ego; it only says that there is no permanent, individual and unchanging self. (Nguyen Quy Hoang, 2019)

4. Benefits of practicing the non-self theory

4.1. Stopping fear and anxiety

Intensive practicing of the teachings of Anatta sutta supports practitioners put an end to fear and anxiety by seeing the continuous change of dharmas according to the law of impermanence. The theory of non-self is a tool to assist people to remove suffering and stress (Nguyen Quy Hoang, 2019) as the fundamental therapy of the mind. In addition, selflessness helps people overcome negative emotions caused by it (Obhasa & Malik, M. M., 2022). Because psychological states naturally change, arise, exist and perish regardless of a peaceful mind, they are not “me, I, and my self” (Samyutta Nikaya, III, 66). Such deep and long-term contemplation helps practitioners stop fears and worries.

4.2. Achieving insight wisdom

The Buddhist insight is that “there is no such thing as permanent and everything that exists is temporary” (Vargas, M., 2021). Therefore, Buddhist followers see the true nature of dharmas as dependent arising, impermanent, without self-nature, not identified with any specific manifestation of oneself (Engler, J., & Fulton, P. R., 1988). The purpose of Buddhist teachings is to objectively and altruistically alleviate all suffering (Vargas, M., 2021). Selfless wisdom illuminates the truth, the very concrete awareness of being nothing

in particular, and therefore the ability to be compassionate towards everything and nothing at all discrimination (Engler, J., & Fulton, P. R., 1988).

4.3. Attaining Nibbhana

From liberated wisdom, practitioners achieve true happiness. Nirvana is the purest state in the process of practice, a state where there are no worldlier impurities. A person with craving, hatred, and delusion cannot have true happiness in life (Nguyen Quy Hoang, 2019). The state of pure Nirvana self-nature means that the meditator realizes that the self-nature is inherently empty, and quiet in the mind. It is a state in which greed, anger, and ignorance have been extinguished, a state of peace due to cessation. Dambrun and Ricard (2011) emphasize that “a state of selflessness leads to true and lasting happiness”. The state is considered the ultimate goal of the self in all cultures (Dambrun & Ricard, 2011; Johnson, 2015). The happiness is not affected by time or space, nor is it corrupted by defilements.

5. Limitations

The doctrine of non-self is receiving more attention from Western scholars because of its applicability; however, Nguyen Quy Hoang's (2019) only gives a general overview of non-self in the system of non-self. Theravada Buddhism without its specific applications. On the other hand, selflessness is applied in reducing stress and suffering (Obhasa & Malik, M. M., 2022) but it has not yet been exploited to transform suffering in different situations, such as illness. In some other research articles, there is mention of non-self, but the research object is only in the form of Buddhists or oneself and people in general (Engler, J., & Fulton, P. R., 1988; Vargas, M., 2021; Shiah YJ, 2016; Miri Albahari, M., 2014) without mentioning specific objects and how to practically apply it to achieve the best results.

This study only lasted eleven weeks, the research team would like to have more time to observe, record, and analyze deeply all of the causes of the suffering of illness and the practical meaning of applying the non-self sutta. Additionally, the respondents will be limited because the participants only the 15th DED students at VBU.

METHODOLOGY

1. Research method

In this study, the research team combined qualitative and quantitative methods to clarify the objectives of the topic. Strecker (2019) state that: “Quantitative research is expressed in numbers and graphs. It is used to validate or put theories and assumptions to the test. A topic's generalizable facts can be established through this kind of study. Qualitative research is expressed in words. It aids in understanding ideas, experiences, or concepts.”

In other words, while qualitative research is normally better at determining "why" and "how," quantitative research is typically better at determining "what" is happening. Qualitative research is particularly useful in investigating something that is poorly understood or that cannot be separated from its context (Szajnfarber and Gralla, 2017). Thus, the researchers used both qualitative and quantitative methodologies in the study to design the questionnaire in order to support for the purpose of the research.

2. Location

Vietnam Buddhist University, abbreviated as VBU, was established and put into operation in 1984 and has grown strongly through many stages. From 1983 to 1997, the school was called Advanced Buddhist Studies in Vietnam, led by the late Venerable Thich Minh Chau as the Founder. From 1997 to 2005, the school officially changed its name to Vietnam Buddhist University in Ho Chi Minh City. In the 2006 school year, the school converted the annual program into credit according to the most advanced and universal education system in the world. In 2009, Venerable Thich Tri Quang inherited the educational career that has continued until now. The Vietnam Buddhist University in Ho Chi Minh City has marked an important turning point, which is to build more campuses 2 according to the residential training model to meet the aspirations of monks and nuns to study and research Buddhism and lay Buddhists. Currently, VBU in Ho Chi Minh City is the largest Buddhist center and the first Buddhist university with 13 faculties. The purpose is to meet the needs of Buddhist work and solve the problems of the time. Every year, hundreds of students, after graduating from VBU in Ho Chi Minh City, continue to study

in many countries with Master's, College, and Doctoral degrees from many different departments and specialties.

3. Participants

The research was supported by the Dharma English Department students, course 15. The research objects are the final year students, currently studying and boarder at Campus 2 at Vietnam Buddhist University in Ho Chi Minh City (VBU). Thus, the 15th DED students have knowledge and experience of Buddhist teachings such as impermanence, not-self, the five aggregates, the four noble truths, etc. to provide support for these topics.

4. Data design

This questionnaire design includes three main ideas and 9 qualitative and quantitative questions and has been approved by the teacher guiding the research topic. The first part is the cause of the suffering and illness of the 15th DED students at VBU. The second idea is the benefit of applying the Sutra of No-Self to overcome suffering. Finally, the method of applying the Sutra of No-Self to overcome suffering. These nine qualitative and quantitative questions are completely open-ended, including seven qualitative, one quantitative, and one that combines qualitative and quantitative methods.

5. Data collection

The questionnaire was designed on Google Form and then submitted for instructors to approve and when they were accepted, the research team sent the questionnaire to the personal Zalo of 59 members in the Dharma English Department, course 15. After 3 days of sending the questionnaire, the research team received back 59 complete answers marked.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

I. RESULT

1. The causes of the sufferings of illnesses of the 15th Dharma English Department students, at VBU

1.1. The problems of the boarding house typically at VBU

The first bar chart states the different levels of anxiety and fear of the DED students, course 15. In the 58 students, 76.3% (45 students) fear of not being able to study, which is the highest voted answer. On the contrary, the answer with the lowest number was 5,1% (3 students) afraid of death when monks and nuns get sick at VBU. In addition, 52,5% participants fear of not being able to chant the suttas and meditate (31 students), and 47,5% people fear of not being able to work (28 students). Finally, 35,6% objects feel depressed, sad and frustrated (21 students).

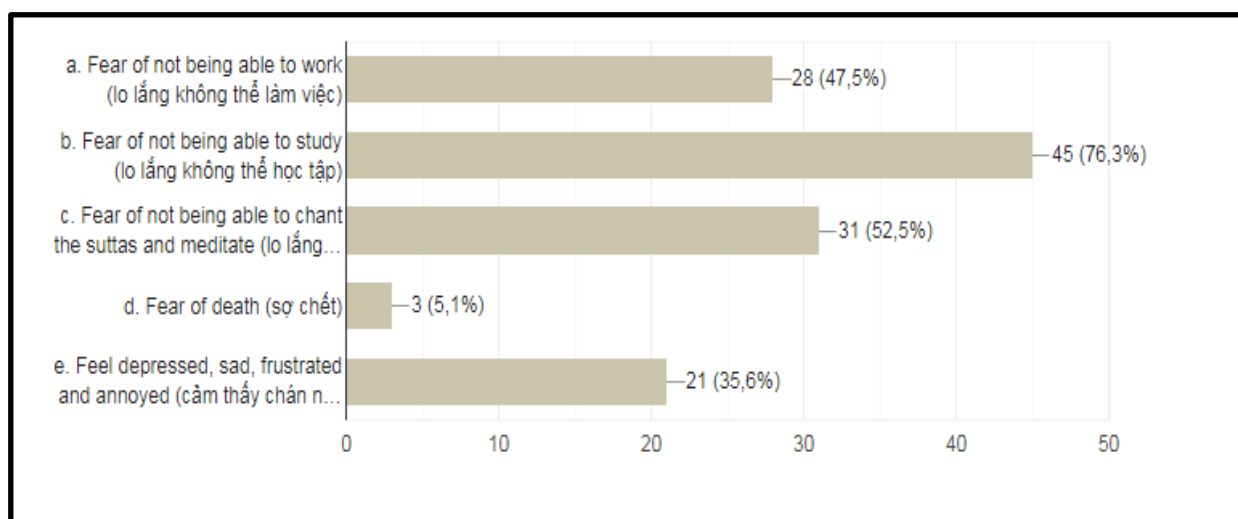


Figure 1. The problem of the boarding house typically at VBU

1.2. The degree of worry experienced of illness

The pie chart of the next question illustrates the level of fear and insecurity when monks and nuns face illness. With 59,3% of students choosing the answer as not often, nearly 4 times more than 15,3% of students, who quite often worry and fear of illness.

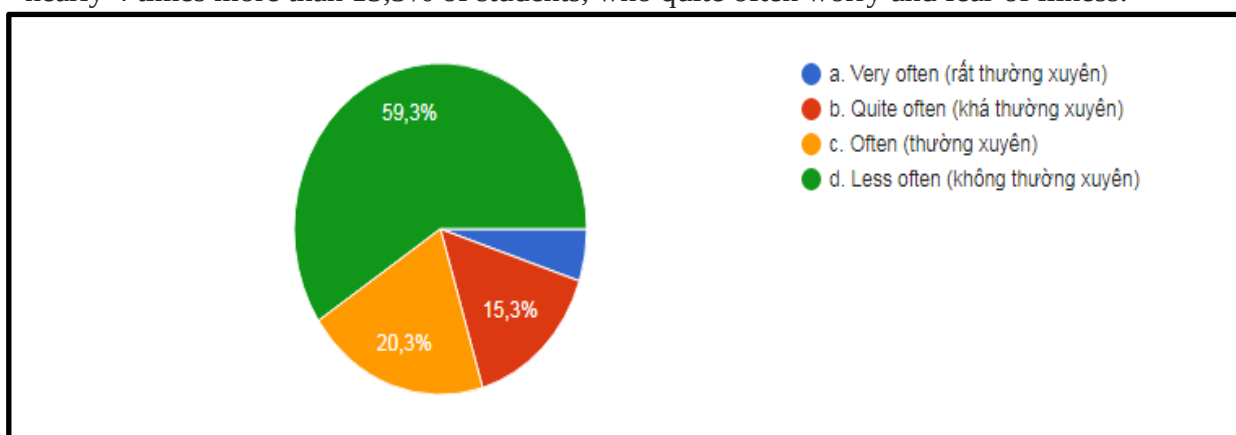


Figure 2. The degree of worry experienced of illness

1.3. Roots of anxiety and insecurity of illness' suffering

The bar chart above firms the students' attachments to form, feelings, thoughts, mental states, and consciousness are the origins of fears and insecurities when participants face illness. Most students chose the answer that fear stems from attachment to sensations, with 40 students (67,8%) voting, and at least, 6 students (10,2%) cling to mental actions.

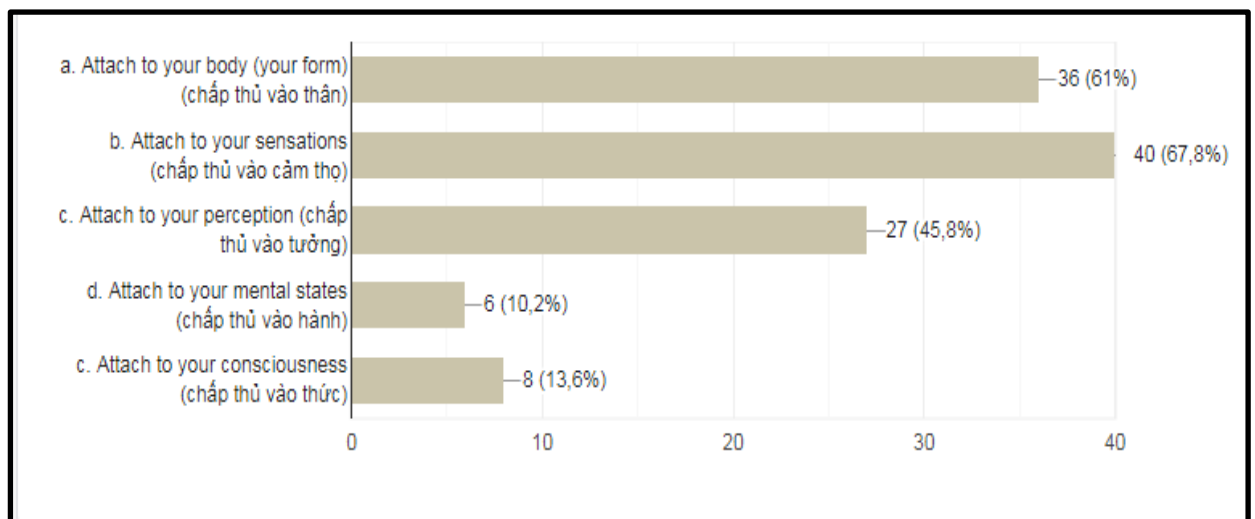
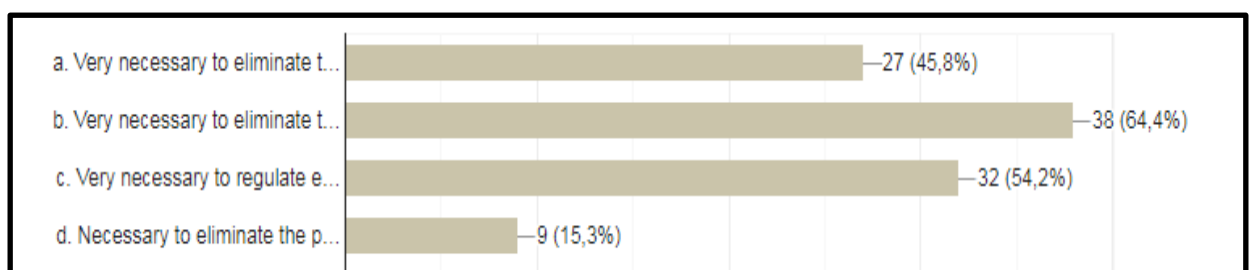


Figure 3. Roots of anxiety and insecurity of illness's suffering

2. Benefits of applying the Non-self sutta to overcome the suffering of illness

2.1. The necessity of applying the Non-self sutta to cease pain caused by disease

The next bar chart emphasizes the necessity of applying the Non-Self sutta to assist DED students of Course 15, at VBU, to overcome fear and anxiety of sickness. The largest number of students (64.4%) select the Non-self sutra as very necessary to eliminate the mental sufferings. On the contrary, 15% is the lowest choice which is necessary to eliminate the physical sufferings. Next, the second largest number of choices with 54.2% is the choice of the non-self sutra, which is very necessary to regulate emotions.



2.2. Helpfulness of using the non-self sutra to heal illness-related suffering

The bar chart below demonstrates the helpfulness of the Sutra of Selflessness to eliminate anxiety and fear. The largest number of votes, 66.1% of students, chose the answer about the usefulness of applying the sutra of selflessness to help eliminate craving and attachment. Less than 6 times the largest number, the smallest is attaining Nirvana (10.2%) and a few other opinions (2%) believe that applying the non-self sutra will help us be at peace and lower our own ego myself. Less than the biggest number of votes, with 50.8% of students voted, will have a right view of the nature of life when applying non-self to overcome anxiety and fear.

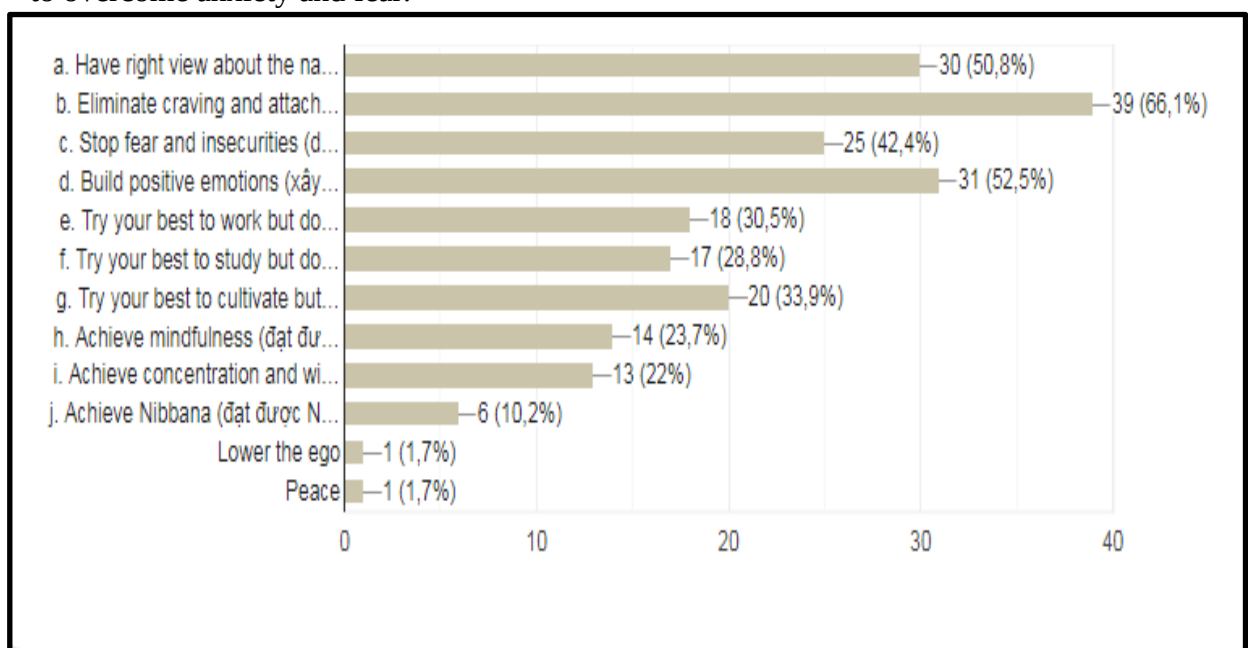


Figure 5. Helpfulness of using the non-self sutra to heal illness-related suffering

2.3. The usefulness of applying the non-self sutta to the Sangha community

The bar chart below express the benefit to the Sangha, when monks and nuns apply the non-self sutta to overcome anxiety about illness. With 62,7% choosing the answer (highest), Buddhist students take care of sick members of the Sangha as if they were taking care of themselves. The least answer is 25,4%, which donate facilities such as money and medicine for sick members, with a number of votes of 25.4%. The remaining opinions, accounting for 1,7%, raised personal opinions about the benefits to the Sangha when students apply the no-self sutta. Besides, 55.9% chose the answer that would sympathize and encourage other members of the Sangha.

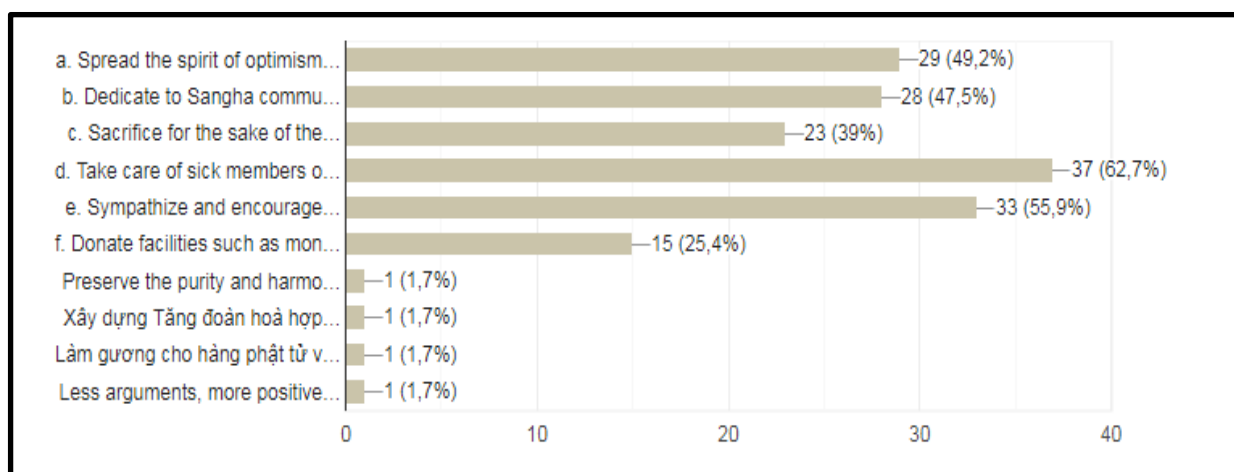


Figure 6. The usefulness of applying the non-self sutta to the Sangha community

3. Methods of applying the non-self sutta to overcome the suffering of illness

3.1. The difficulties of practising the no-self sutta in the boarding environment at VBU

The bar chart in this question reviews the difficulty of students applying the Sutta of not-self. Students can choose multiple answers at the same time or suggest difficulties that are not included in the answers that they encounter when practicing according to the

no-self sutra. With 35 students, equivalent to 59,3% (the greatest), responding, agree that applying the sutra of non-self be easy to fall in the attachment to emptiness. At least, 12 people (20.3%) voting "not trying to practice because of attachment to emptiness". The rest voted for other opinions and recorded the difficulties the students encountered.

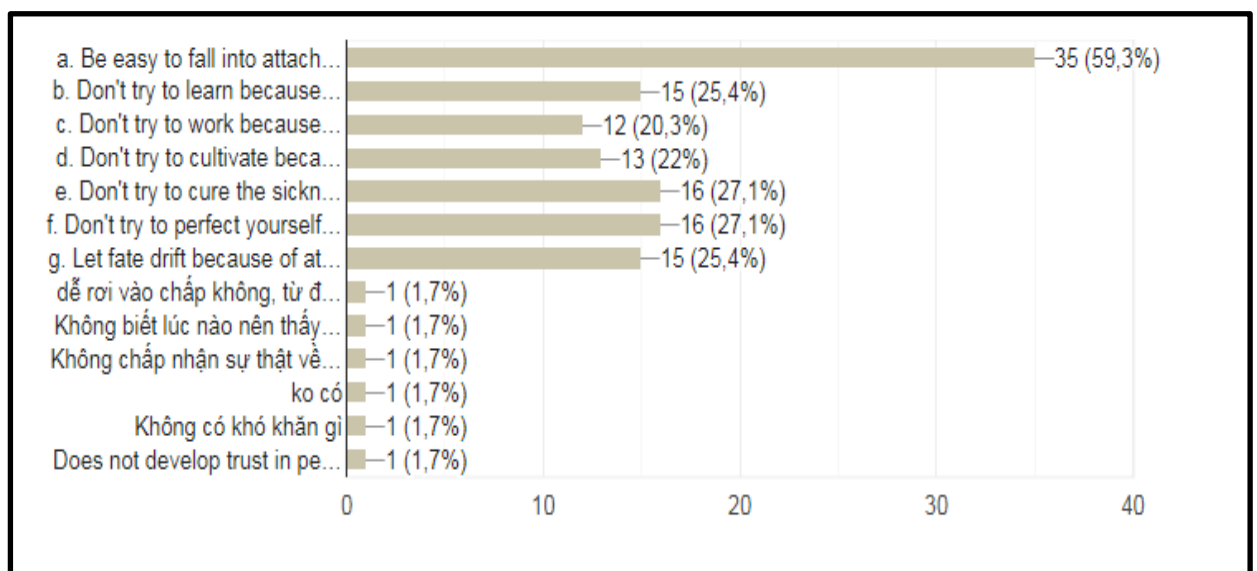
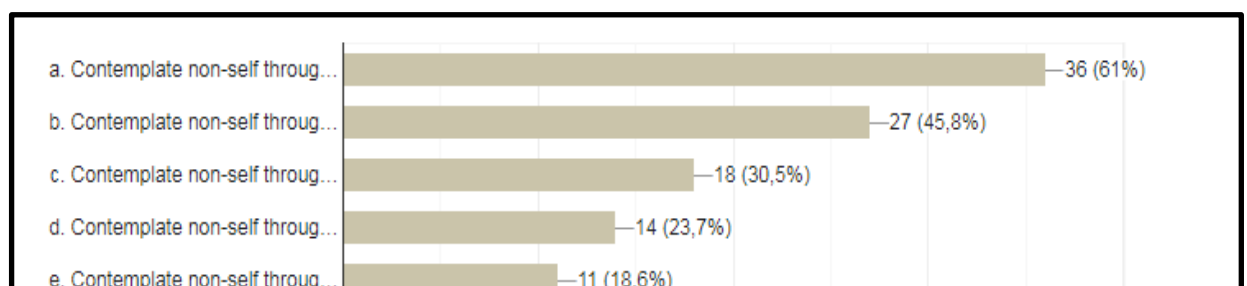


Figure 7. The difficulties of practicing the no-self sutra in the

boarding environment at VBU

3.2. The ways of non-self to overcome illness's effects

Figure 8 is a bar chart, pointing out the method of contemplating non-self, that students of the Dharma English Department apply to overcome the suffering of illness when sick at VBU. With the highest vote of 61%, the students used the method of contemplating non-self through a temporary composite of the five aggregates. And the method of contemplation has the lowest number of votes: 18,6% of students choose to contemplate non-self through the Four Noble Truths.



4.3.3 The methods of practicing through the non-self sutta to overcome suffering

The method in the Anatta Sutta that many students apply will be confirmed in the bar chart in Figure 9. There are five methods of Contemplation, which are contemplation of the true nature of the body, feelings, thoughts, actions and consciousness. The method with the most number of students voting is 76.3% (45 students), the method of contemplating the true nature of the body as suffering, impermanence, and non-self. The method of contemplation of the true nature of consciousness as suffering, impermanence, and no-self has the least votes, 16.9% (10 students).

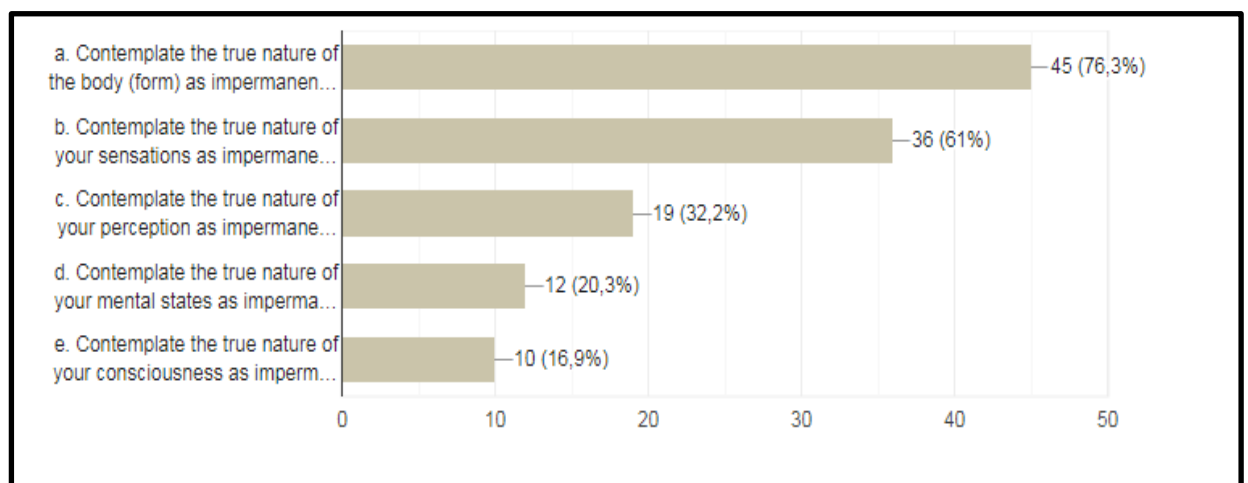


Figure 9. The methods the students practice the non-self sutta to overcome Suffering of illness

II. DISCUSSION

After the researchers received the questionnaire results about the topic “the causes of the sufferings of illnesses of the 15th Dharma English Department students, at VBU, this study further affirms that the Buddhist students should apply the Non-self sutra to overcome the misery of sickness and attain the benefits of practicing the sutra through providing indication in the Literature Review and the practical suggestions in the answers of the questionnaire. The content of the research article has 3 main points.

The first main argument is the causes of illness grieves for the 15th DED students. The questionnaire shows the boarding environment at VBU affects the suffering of disease. With the strictness of the regulations and rules, monks and nuns are afraid of not completing the work, studying, and reciting sutras. The evidence is that 76.5% of the votes voted for the answer “fear of not being able to study”, 52,5% participants fear of not being able to chant the suttas and meditate (31 students), and 47,5% fear of not being able to work (28 students). Montoro et al. (2012) asserted that the environmental context is one of the causes of the disease’s suffering as “the disease turns into an invalidating factor that prevents subjects from following their normal work rhythm.” by analyzing a patient’s reaction as follows: “It wasn’t just my disease, but the external pressure I was getting...” (p.625). Thus, the reason satisfies 80% of the research’s objectives. On the contrary, only a few (5,1%) chose the answer of fear of death and not being able to meet the set goals. In term of degree of suffering, the answer only appropriates 40.7% of the goal set by the research, which defects 50.93%. However, monks and nuns are still worried and afraid of illness at VBU. Moreover, the result confirms the roots of anxiety and insecurity of sickness’ suffering fear stems from attachment to sensations and form, with 40 and 36 selections (67,8% and 61%), which is consistent with the objectives of the study. In addition, 10,2% students suffer because of the mental states. In the Anattalakkhaṇa sutra, the Buddha also stated that attachment to form and sensations is suffering. Besides the problems of residential life, Buddhist students also encounter difficulties when practicing the sutra of selflessness.

Through the result, with 59,3%, the most trouble is that applying the sutra of non-self be easy to fall in the attachment to emptiness.

With the reasons mentioned above, the study has suggested specific methods. The most effective method voted by 61% of the votes is the contemplating non-self through a temporary composite of the five aggregates, which is suitable for the goal. In which, the methods of reflecting on the nature of the form and sensations are the highest agreements of Bhikkhus and Bhikkhunis. These solutions are completely relevant with the causes raised above and the objectives of the research.

With the above results, the research team further reaffirmed that the given goal is extremely practical. Most participants selected that the sutra of Selflessness is a necessary to eliminate the mental sufferings and regulate the emotions because the Non-self discourse assists practitioners to cease craving and attachment. Furthermore, the research also supports monks and nuns to have a right vision of the sutra of non-self in Therapy. Thanks to that, students enhance the knowledge and gain positive emotions of illness.

The respondents' positive perception of effectiveness is shown through the opinions on the application of the Non-self sutra by monks and nuns at VBU. However, the Buddhist students faced many difficulties of applying the methods of applying the non-self sutra to overcome the suffering of illness. Attachment to emptiness is the greatest limitation for monks and nuns. Though, the arguments of previous articles only generally talk about disease symptoms as well as treatment methods, yet not researched to clarify the cause and applied the the non-self sermon to thoroughly eliminate the root of the disease and bring people the true health and peace. Consequently, applying the non-self sutra allows individuals to comprehend the nature of the body without wishing to satisfy their craving for self or attachment to any object. As a result, practicing the non-self sutra leads to release the mental suffering and strengthen the physical health. The benefits have been proven by Dalai Lama (1995) as "Buddhist practice traditionally takes place in the context of spiritual development leading to enlightenment in the form of experience of the non-self, a state of total liberation and authentic and durable happiness".

CONCLUSION

In short, people obviously suffer from both physical and mental illness; however, with the Buddhist perspective, the current researchers only focus on treating mental pain. Because the research participants are mostly students of the 15th DEDD and live in the same study environment, research will be easier. Furthermore, these research objects are the future of Vietnamese Buddhism, so finding a method to help them overcome their mental suffering is extremely necessary. When DED students' own spirits are strong, they can transmit positive energy to everyone around them.

The study shows that the reason the participants suffered of sickness, which are fears stem from attachment to 'self' due. Therefore, the ways to eliminate suffering is also cut off 'self-attachment', i.e., the methods of practicing the Non-self discourse. Colzato et al. (2012) argues that "Non-self theory offers additional insight that many of the issues linked to the self and delusional constructs. When an individual successfully manages to use the concept of Anatta to eliminate the impediments between self and others". Applying the Anatta sutra aid participants to achieve practical benefits as the goal set by the researchers. Van Gordon et al. (2015) reveal that the concept of non-self assists mental health practitioners in understanding patients' attachments. Hence, Anatta can be an essential tool for Western practitioners due to its ability to develop empathy and create a therapeutic nexus between the patient and the therapist.

Anatta helps Buddhist followers to know the concepts of self is not merely delusional but also closely associated with the five heaps of clinging. Such a comprehension could be the cue to liberating those who grasp too strongly the notion of self. Through the same understanding of the "no-self" concept, monks and nuns appreciate the significance of releasing the relentless pursuit of craving, especially those that from the five aggregates, which is agreed upon by the majority of students.

By embracing Anatta, monastics' basis of negative motions can be eliminated. As a result, practitioners live freely without fears and insecurity of illness.

However, the research still has many shortcomings. First, because the time and research objects are limited, researchers do not have more general methods and practical benefits. Second, the study has not resolved the causes of treatment facilities such as money and medicine for the 15th DED students, who do not have good conditions. The problem of money is also one of the worries of monastics. To address those limitations, the researchers hope that future articles will have more time and a broader object's research. In addition, later research should study the impact of treatment facilities on the mental suffering of monks and nuns.

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APPENDIXES

Appendixes 1 - The questionnaire from current researchers

Dear Buddhist students,

We are seniors of the Dharma English Department (DED), the 15th course, at VBU in HCMC. We are learning Scientific Research Methodology and researching on a topic “*Benefits of applying the non-self sutta to overcome the suffering of illness in the Department of English Dhamma Course 15 at VBU in HCMC.*” Please take your time to complete the questionnaire. All information is analyzed by our research team in the content of the article and is kept confidential.

Thank you very much for your contribution.

Xin chào Quý Tăng Ni sinh khoa Anh Văn Phật pháp khóa 15!

Chúng con là sinh viên năm thứ ba, khoa Anh Văn Phật pháp khóa 15 tại Học viện Phật giáo Việt Nam tại Thành phố Hồ Chí Minh. Chúng con đang học môn Nghiên cứu Khoa học và đang thực hiện đề tài “Lợi ích của việc áp dụng kinh Vô Ngã Tướng để vượt qua các nỗi khổ của bệnh tật đối với sinh viên khoa Anh Văn Phật pháp tại Học viện Phật giáo Việt Nam Thành phố Hồ Chí Minh”. Kính mong quý Thầy (Cô) vui lòng dành ít thời gian để hoàn thành bảng câu hỏi. Mọi thông tin được nhóm chúng con phân tích trong bài nghiên cứu và được giữ bí mật.

Xin chân thành cảm ơn mọi đóng góp của Quý Thầy (Cô).

QUESTIONNAIRE

(BẢNG HỎI)

I. The causes of the sufferings of illnesses of Dharma English Department students, course 15, at VBU (*Nguyên nhân của các nỗi khổ về bệnh tật của sinh viên khoa Anh Văn Phật pháp khóa 15 khi học tại VBU*)

1. When you are sick, what insecurities do you usually face at VBU? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Những nỗi bất an mà Quý Thầy/Cô gặp phải khi bị bệnh tại VBU là gì? Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn 1 câu trả lời*)
 - a. Fear of not being able to work (*lo lắng không thể làm việc*)
 - b. Fear of not being able to study (*lo lắng không thể học tập*)

- c. Fear of not being able to chant the suttas and meditate (*lo lắng không thể tụng kinh và ngồi thiền*)
 - d. Fear of death (*sợ chết*)
 - e. Feel depressed, sad, frustrated and annoyed (*cảm thấy chán nản, sầu khổ, bức bối và khó chịu*)
2. How often do you face insecurities and fears when you get sick at VBU? (*Quý Thầy/Cô có thường xuyên đối mặt với các nỗi bất an và sợ hãi khi bị bệnh tại VBU?*)
- a. Very often (*rất thường xuyên*)
 - b. Quite often (*khá thường xuyên*)
 - c. Often (*thường xuyên*)
 - d. Less often (*không thường xuyên*)
3. In your opinion, what do these fears and insecurities (in question 2) come from? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Theo Quý Thầy/Cô, các nỗi sợ hãi và bất an (ở câu 2) bắt nguồn từ nguyên nhân nào? Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn 1 câu trả lời*)
- a. Attach to your body (your form) (*chấp thủ vào thân*)
 - b. Attach to your sensations (*chấp thủ vào cảm thọ*)
 - a. Attach to your perception (*chấp thủ vào tưởng*)
 - b. Attach to your mental states (*chấp thủ vào hành*)
 - c. Attach to your consciousness (*chấp thủ vào thức*)

II. Benefits of applying the Non-self sutta to overcome the suffering of illness (*Lợi ích của việc ứng dụng kinh Vô Ngã Tướng để vượt qua các nỗi khổ của bệnh*)

4. How necessary is the Non-Self sutta to eliminate the illness-related sufferings? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Quý Thầy/Cô nghĩ rằng kinh Vô Ngã Tướng cần thiết như thế nào để loại trừ các nỗi khổ liên quan đến bệnh tật? Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn một câu trả lời*)
- a. Very necessary to eliminate the physical sufferings (*rất cần thiết để đoạn các nỗi khổ về thể chất*)
 - b. Very necessary to eliminate the mental sufferings (*rất cần thiết để đoạn các nỗi khổ về tinh thần*)
 - c. Very necessary to regulate emotions (*rất cần thiết để điều hòa cảm xúc*)
 - d. Necessary to eliminate the physical sufferings (*cần thiết để đoạn các nỗi khổ về thể chất*)

- e. Necessary to eliminate the mental sufferings (*cần thiết để đoạn các nỗi khổ về tinh thần*)
 - f. Less necessary in getting rid of the physical sufferings (*ít cần thiết trong việc chữa trị các nỗi khổ về thể chất*)
 - g. Less necessary in getting rid of the mental sufferings (*ít cần thiết trong việc chữa trị các nỗi khổ về tinh thần*)
5. What benefits of applying the Non-self sutta bring to you? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Lợi ích của việc áp dụng kinh Vô Ngã Tướng mang lại cho Quý Thầy/Cô là gì? Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn 1 câu trả lời*)
- a. Have right view about the nature of life (*có chánh kiến về bản chất của cuộc đời*)
 - b. Eliminate craving and attachment (*loại bỏ tham ái và chấp thủ*)
 - c. Stop fear and insecurities (*dừng sợ hãi và bất an*)
 - d. Build positive emotions (*xây dựng cảm xúc lạc quan*)
 - e. Try your best to work but don't get attached to your work (*Cố gắng làm việc nhưng không chấp vào việc mình làm*)
 - f. Try your best to study but don't get attached to your scores (*Cố gắng học nhưng không chấp vào điểm số*)
 - g. Try your best to cultivate but don't get attached to your attainment (*Cố gắng tu tập nhưng không chấp vào thành tựu*)
 - h. Achieve mindfulness (*đạt được chánh niệm*)
 - i. Achieve concentration and wisdom (*đạt được thiền định và trí tuệ*)
 - j. Achieve Nibbana (*đạt được Niết-bàn*)
 - k. Other answer
6. What benefits of applying the non-self sutta bring to Sangha community? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Lợi ích của việc ứng dụng kinh Vô Ngã Tướng mang lại cho Tăng đoàn là gì? Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn 1 câu trả lời*)
- a. Spread the spirit of optimism (*Truyền tinh thần lạc quan*)
 - b. Dedicate to Sangha community enthusiastically (*cống hiến hết sức mình cho Tăng đoàn*)
 - c. Sacrifice for the sake of the Sangha (*hy sinh vì lợi ích của Tăng đoàn*)
 - d. Take care of sick members of the Sangha as you take care of yourself (*chăm sóc cho các thành viên bị bệnh của Tăng đoàn như là chăm sóc cho chính mình*)

- e. Sympathize and encourage sick members of the Sangha (*cảm thông và động viên các thành viên bị bệnh trong Tăng đoàn*)
- f. Donate facilities such as money and medicine to sick members (*ủng hộ các phương tiện như tiền và thuốc men cho các thành viên bị bệnh*)
- g. Other answer

III. Methods of applying the non-self sutta to overcome the suffering of illness (*Phương pháp áp dụng kinh vô ngã tướng để vượt qua các nỗi khổ về bệnh tật*)

7. What are difficulties when you practice the non-self sutta in VBU? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Quý Thầy/Cô thường gặp phải khó khăn gì khi thực hành kinh Vô Ngã Tướng tại VBU? Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn 1 câu trả lời*)
 - a. Be easy to fall into attachment of emptiness (*dễ rơi vào chấp không*)
 - b. Don't try to learn because of grasping to emptiness (*không cố gắng học bởi vì chấp không*)
 - c. Don't try to work because of attaching to emptiness (*không cố gắng làm bởi vì chấp không*)
 - d. Don't try to cultivate because of attaching to emptiness (*không cố gắng tu tập bởi vì chấp không*)
 - e. Don't try to cure the sickness because of attaching to emptiness (*không cố gắng chữa bệnh bởi vì chấp không*)
 - f. Don't try to perfect yourself because of attaching to emptiness (*không cố gắng hoàn thiện bản thân bởi vì chấp không*)
 - g. Let fate drift because of attaching to emptiness (*thả trôi số phận bởi vì chấp không*)
 - h. Other answer
8. What methods of non-self do you practice to overcome the sufferings of illness at VBU? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Quý Thầy/Cô đã quán vô ngã theo những phương pháp nào để vượt qua các nỗi khổ của bệnh tật khi bị bệnh tại VBU Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn 1 câu trả lời*)
 - a. Contemplate non-self through a temporary composite of the five aggregates (*quán vô ngã thông qua sự giả hợp của ngũ uẩn*)
 - b. Contemplate non-self through the four elements (earth, water, wind, fire) (*quán vô ngã thông qua tứ đại*)

- c. Contemplate non-self through the theory of cause and effect (*quán vô ngã thông qua thuyết nhân quả*)
 - d. Contemplate non-self through the twelve causes and conditions. (*quán vô ngã thông qua mười hai nhân duyên*)
 - e. Contemplate non-self through the four noble truths) (*quán vô ngã thông qua Tứ Diệu Đế*)
 - f. Contemplate non-self through the emptiness of all things (*quán vô ngã thông qua tánh không của vạn pháp*)
 - g. Contemplate non-self through the self-nature of all things (*quán vô ngã thông qua tự tánh của vạn pháp*)
9. Which of the following methods do you practice through the Non-self sutta to overcome the insecurities and fears when you get sick at VBU? You can choose more than 1 answer (*Quý Thầy/Cô đã áp dụng phương pháp nào trong kinh Vô Ngã Tướng để vượt qua các nỗi bất an và lo lắng khi bệnh tại VBU? Quý Thầy/Cô có thể chọn nhiều hơn 1 câu trả lời*)
- a. Contemplate the true nature of the body (form) as impermanent, suffering and not-self. (*quán bản chất thật của thân là khổ, vô thường, và vô ngã*)
 - b. Contemplate the true nature of your sensations as impermanent, suffering and not-self. (*quán bản chất thật của cảm thọ là khổ, vô thường, và vô ngã*)
 - c. Contemplate the true nature of your perception as impermanent, suffering and not-self. (*quán bản chất thật của tưởng là khổ, vô thường, và vô ngã*)
 - d. Contemplate the true nature of your mental states as impermanent, suffering and not-self. (*quán bản chất thật của các hành là khổ, vô thường, và vô ngã*)
 - e. Contemplate the true nature of your consciousness as impermanent, suffering and not-self. (*quán bản chất thật của thức là khổ, vô thường, và vô ngã*)

THE END

